Words to Say at the End of the World

By Mark W. Sasse

Mom, an overbearing mother preparing her daughter for college
Sally, a sassy teen who's ready to leave for college

Setting: Anywhere, modern time

Mother packing a suitcase, looking around frantically. Daughter is busy on her phone.

MOM: **(Pg 66-77)** Sally, do you have everything?

SALLY: *(rolling her eyes)* Yes, we went over the list five times.

MOM: Do you have your passport?

SALLY: Yes.

MOM: Toothbrush?

SALLY: Yes, Mom. I know how to pack.

MOM: But you've never packed for college before.

SALLY: But I've been brushing my teeth every day of my life. I'm not a little girl anymore.

MOM: *(handing her a piece of paper)* Now here's a list of all our numbers. Mine. Dad's. Uncle Sy. Mrs. Cho from across the street. Police. Fireman. Family doctor. Chiropractor.

SALLY: Chiropractor?

MOM: You're not going to be used to those college beds. You might tweak your back.

SALLY: Mom, I have a phone. It has everyone's numbers in it.

MOM: I know, but I just want you to be prepared. Here take this paper in case you lose your phone. *(There is a huge explosion that shakes them and knocks them nearly off their feet.)*

SALLY: What was that? *(Sally looks up above the audience, awestruck)*

MOM: *(tightening a strap on the suitcase)* It's probably a gas explosion at the airport.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *According to Victor Gilinsky, program advisor to The Nonproliferation Policy Education Center, in the years since Hiroshima and Nagasaki, nuclear war has become an abstraction, stripped of its horrors.*

ACTRESS 2: *North Korea and the United States exchanged threats of annihilation. Pakistan and India have issued nuclear threats and counter threats. And do we really know how close Iran is to developing their own nuclear weapons?*

ACTRESS 1: *Oh, I know, it's easy to put nuclear weapons out of mind, to let sleeping dogs lie. The weapons play essentially no role in day-to-day life. Even Hollywood has given up making apocalyptic nuclear war movies.*

ACTRESS 2: *But the nuclear weapons aren't asleep. They are ready to go.*

TOGETHER: *Words to Say at the End of the World by Mark W. Sasse*

SALLY: *(staring straight ahead)* Mom . . . .

MOM: Maybe you should stay home and go next semester.

SALLY: Mom . . . .

MOM: You are young for college anyways …

SALLY: *(screams)* Mom!

MOM: What is it? *(She turns around and looks up.)* That's a mushroom cloud.

SALLY: *(frightened)* Uh-huh.

MOM: *(matter-of-factly)* That's not supposed to happen.

SALLY: *(frightened)* No. *(They reach out to hold each other's hand, and then freeze for a second.)*

MOM: Pause. *(takes a deep breath and let's go of Sally's hand)* Can we just slow time down for a second? I need a moment to ponder this. *(to audience, daughter still looking at the mushroom cloud, melancholic)* It doesn't seem fair. I've been preparing my daughter for this day her entire life, and on the day I send her off to college, someone drops a nuclear bomb in our backyard. Now you may wonder how I have so much time to talk with you if a nuclear explosion is just north of us a few hundred meters. That's a fair question. It has to do with the equilibrium of time. I read about this on Facebook. There's always a give or take when the sandman comes calling to steal time. He always gives a little back, just for a

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moment. Don't believe me? Did you ever slam your finger in a door and then consciously think how painful it will feel as soon as that electric synapse sends the signal to your brain? Why just the other day I slipped on a plastic bag which was on my hard tile floor, and before gravity body-slammed me onto that marble, I had time to plan dinner for a week, think out my Christmas shopping list, and even say a little prayer that I wouldn't bruise too badly. Poor Sally. *(She turns to her and touches her hair.)* She'll never get to experience college or marriage. I'll never see my grandchildren. *(motions quickly like insects are flying around her; she keeps swatting them away.)* The memories. Flashing. Thick as a swarm of bees. Stinging. They sting my eyes. They ... *(Suddenly she gets a big smile on her face as that of a mother looking at a baby. Sally gets down on her knees and pretends like she's a baby.)* Look at how adorable she was. Oh ... but *(She catches a memory from the sky, and it sours mother's attitude.)* She got colicky real quick and then ... *(Sally starts crying. Mom points down at Sally)* She did that. A lot. Non-stop crying. *(Sally continues crying.)* The only thing that made her stop was either to carry her outside or lay her on the floor butt-naked. I have pictures around here somewhere, but I'll spare you the details. *(She looks up and sees another memory.)* And then she hit her terrible twos. *(Sally takes off and runs around like crazy.)* From non-stop crying to non-stop movement.

SALLY: *(running around the room)* Da-da-da-da-da-da-da-da-da.

MOM: And noise. Constant noise. I did everything for her, but would she say 'Mom'? No! Only ...

SALLY: Da-da-da.

MOM: I think she did it to spite me! And then the first day of school. *(turns to Sally)* Here's your lunch and hat. Don't eat too quickly, and save the fruit for last.

SALLY: Yes, Mommy.

MOM: And straighten your collar. Remember to be polite, don't take candy from strangers, stay away from the neighbor's dog, and always remember to ... *(Sally morphs to an older age, now wearing braces.)* The years go by so quickly.

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SALLY: Mom, these braces hurt my gums.

MOM: Stop your whining. You know how much those cost?

SALLY: Mom! But you don't know what it's like.

MOM: You're right, you ungrateful child. I don't know what it's like because we were dirt poor. Too poor for dental work. You don't know how good you have it. When I was your age ...

SALLY: *(sassy)* You walked to school, uphill both ways, in four feet of snow, even though you lived in the tropics. *(Sally freezes, looking back at the cloud.)*

MOM: *(to audience)* I don't miss that age. *(another memory flashes by)* But before I knew it, she was sixteen. *(Sally becomes older.)*

SALLY: *(on her phone)* Mom, can I spend the night at Lili's house?

MOM: No, you have that science paper to write, don't you?

SALLY: *(on her phone)* Just chill. I'll get it done.

MOM: Did you tell me to chill? I won't chill.

SALLY: Yeah, don't I know it.

MOM: What's that supposed to mean?

SALLY: *(overly dramatic)* You're strangling me. I can't go anywhere or do anything.

MOM: Just because I care about my daughter ...

SALLY: Please care less. *(Sally goes back to her suitcase and looks up at the mushroom cloud again.)*

MOM: *(to audience)* Almost makes me miss the days of the braces. She always had a mouth on her. Today. A college freshman. *(emotional)* Look at her. I don't want to turn away, but I have to think of something. *(looking up at the sky)* There must be a way to stop this. *(Mom freezes, reaches back and takes her hand, looking up at the mushroom cloud.)*

SALLY: *(Unfreezes, drop's Mom's hand, and addresses the audience.)* My Mom has always been a little overbearing and completely in control of everything. Undoubtedly, this mushroom cloud is freaking her out. How do you control that? *(pointing)* But don't get me

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wrong, if there is an obscure way to survive a nuclear holocaust, she'll find it, or die trying. From the time I was just a little wee girl, she never let me out of her sight. Okay, maybe that's a bad example. But, here's one. Just last year a ... boy asked me out, and I asked Mom if ... *(She turns to her mother and her mother unfreezes.)* Mom, can I go out with Tony tonight?

MOM: Is that Tony with an 'i' or with a 'y'?

SALLY: 'Y'

MOM: Because I have to know.

SALLY: I said 'y'. Tony with a 'y'.

MOM: Then the answer is no.

SALLY: It won't even inconvenience you. He has his own car.

MOM: That's supposed to make me feel better? You are not getting in that car with that boy.

SALLY: You are so unfair. Why not?

MOM: Because he can't be trusted.

SALLY: His father is Dad's best friend.

MOM: What better reason not to trust him? I know how your father thinks.

SALLY: That makes no sense.

MOM: You know what makes no sense? Standing here arguing with a fifteen-year-old girl, who thinks she's all that, and hot stuff and sassy enough for a 17-year-old loser with a broken down twenty-year-old car.

SALLY: Mom, I'm 17!

MOM: Well, your brains are only 15. *(Mom goes back to looking at the mushroom cloud.)*

SALLY: *(to audience)* Classic Mom. I remember when I was ten. My best friend, Agnes, started taking Taekwondo lessons, and I told my Mom I wanted to do it too.

MOM: *(turning back towards Sally)* Why do you want to run around on a padded floor like a crazed lunatic and kick your legs in the air?

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SALLY: *(as a 10-year-old)* It's fun! Watch! *(She kicks her Mom in the behind and starts laughing and running around doing other martial arts poses.)*

MOM: You are an evil child.

SALLY: Why can't I, Mom? Why can't I? All of my friends are doing it.

MOM: They are? That's the best reason not to do it. That's what we call opportunity. What do I always tell you to do when opportunity knocks?

SALLY: You kick its butt! *(kick, jump, other moves)* That's why I need to do this so I can knock opportunity to the floor. *(Mom grabs her ear and takes her to a desk.)*

MOM: No, silly girl. Who puts these notions in your head? Don't you understand? If you study your math and go to extra lessons after school while your friends are sweating in baggy clothes, then you will be the one with the best test scores. You will be the one who goes to the best college.

SALLY: *(defiant)* But I want to do Taekwondo!

MOM: It's Taekwon-DON'T! Not Taekwon-DOO!

SALLY: *(spitefully)* Well, I DOO not care for math.

MOM: Well, I DOO not care that you DOO not care for. Math! *(Mom goes back to looking at the cloud.)*

SALLY: I hated sitting at that table, spending all my evenings in additional classes. I used to scream: "No, I don't want to go. I don't care about numbers anymore!" *(starts laughing)* We certainly did have our rough patches. *(looking at her Mom)* But I see it now for what it was. If it wasn't for her, I wouldn't be here today with a suitcase packed for college. *(Sally goes back to look at the cloud.)*

MOM: *(to audience)* I wasn't really that controlling, was I? I just wanted to be strong for her. I wanted her to think that she could do anything she put her mind to. She's so smart. So clever. *(looking at Sally)* I never even finished high school. I wanted a better life for her. But now ... *(Back to live action.)* Sally, we only have a split second ... let's run for the bedroom and get into the closet.

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SALLY: Mom --

MOM: *(frantically)* Come on, if we run to the kitchen and dump out the contents of the refrigerator, we might both be able to fit inside.

SALLY: Mom --

MOM: Sally, you can never give up. Fight till the end. Promise me that.

SALLY: Mom --

MOM: Run to the basement. Now!

SALLY: *(grabbing her arm)* Mom, there's no fixing this.

MOM: But we can't just give up.

SALLY: There's nothing we can do. But there is one thing I need to say before it's too late.

MOM: What's that?

SALLY: I love you, Mom.

(Mom starts crying and they hug each other. Then they turn towards the mushroom cloud, still holding hands, put their chins in the air, and are suddenly blown backwards onto the ground.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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